

Nikhil D'Souza, *Leher*



For his second Hindi EP, co-written with his long-time collaborator, lyricist Pinky Poonawala, indie pop and playback singer Nikhil D'Souza brought the band he tours with into the studio. Consequently, a couple of the heartfelt love ballads, 'Dobara' and 'Tu Keh De Haan', sound bigger and brighter than his earlier work. The likes of 'Muskaan' are rendered in his trademark style, but thanks to D'Souza's emotive delivery, even the heavier tunes feel just as intimate.



comprises tunes from the fourth and last season of the romantic comedy, which concluded in 2021. Adhikari decided to belatedly put them out, perhaps because they're the closest to what he'd make independently. The 1960s-influenced, relationship-centric pop-rock material works even outside the context of the show and, despite the delay, still sounds fresh.

–Amit Gurbaxani

Symphony of Success

***The Musical Maverick* is a detailed account of Shankar Mahadevan's career as a musician and singer**

Over the past three decades, there have been few artists as firmly embedded in the firmament of Indian popular music as Shankar Mahadevan. The singer and composer has left his mark on an incredibly diverse range of musical scenes and genres, from Carnatic music to Indo-jazz fusion, from Indipop to Bollywood blockbusters.

In *The Musical Maverick*, Ashis Ghatak's authorised biography of Shankar Mahadevan, the author documents the life and career of this—as Javed Akhtar succinctly declares in the first sentence of his foreword—"musical genius". Ghatak draws on hundreds of hours of interviews with the musician for the book, supplemented with conversations with a wide assortment of Shankar's contemporaries, from his childhood friends in Chembur to film and music legends like Gulzar, Zakir Hussain and Javed Akhtar.

This surfeit of anecdotal information, alongside Ghatak's extensive musical analysis, mean that *The Musical Maverick* is a cornucopia of Shankar Mahadevan musical trivia. You can read about how Pandit Jasraj refused to teach a young Shankar, only to express regret at his decision after seeing him perform at a show. There's a charming story about a three-year-old Shankar wowing his family with his ability to pick up any tune and replicate it on the harmonium. And the story of the teenage love affair between Shankar and his now-wife Sangeeta reads like a Bollywood romcom.

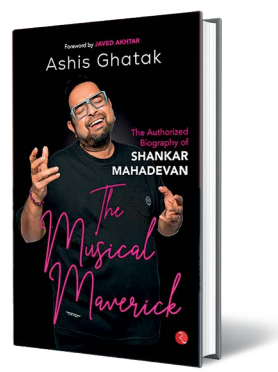
There's also an endless supply of behind-the-scenes anecdotes from the studios, as the author writes about Shankar's many musical endeavours in incredible detail. There are sub-chapters devoted to his time with Indo-fusion bands Shakti and Silk, ad jingles like 'Yahi hai right choice baby, aaha!' for Pepsi, and the making of *Breathless* with Javed Akhtar. Almost half the book is devoted to his work as a composer with Ehsaan Noorani and Loy Mendonsa; each soundtrack they worked on is picked up and analysed.

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Ghatak's talent and rigour as a musical archivist are undeniable. Unfortunately, the same can't be said for his skills as a biographer. He seems so overawed by Shankar that he never really attempts to look at his subject with a dispassionate gaze, or to dig any deeper than the air-brushed 'poster-boy of positivity' public image that Shankar has cultivated. Apart from the early chapters that deal with Shankar's childhood and early adulthood, we never get a glimpse of Shankar's inner world. Nor is there a sense of how Shankar's personality and worldview evolve as he goes from middle-class child prodigy to Grammy-winning superstar.

Instead, we get a hagiographical account with no real narrative arc or insight into what it takes to make it to the top of an insanely competitive music industry. In Ghatak's telling, Shankar coasts through life on raw talent and serendipity alone. Even for an authorised biography, this is a spectacularly 'breathless' piece of fan-service. ■

–Bhanuj Kappal



THE MUSICAL MAVERICK
The Authorised Biography of Shankar Mahadevan
By Ashis Ghatak
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